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It's that time of year! 🎄🏀🥅

Welcome to the 12 Days of Madness, from now till the tournament I'll post on one CBB analytics topic per day based on data from barttorvik.com.

Day 1: Strength of Schedule & Conferences

Does a tougher schedule help teams make deeper runs?

12:25 AM · Mar 7, 2026 · **8** Views

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Metrics used include:
-BARTHAG: a measure of Team Strength
-ELITESOS: a measure of Strength of Schedule

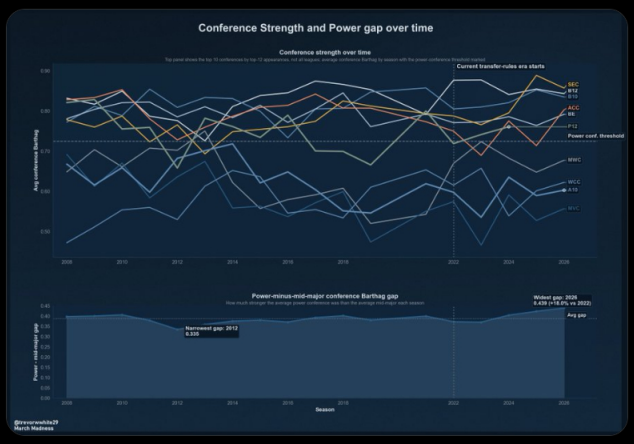
Both "compiled with sacred data and secret formulas" at barttorvik.com.

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To begin, I looked at Conference strength over time to understand how it has evolved to its current state.

After the recent portal era began, we see the SEC's rise, the ACC's volatility, and a growing disparity between Power conferences and mid-majors.



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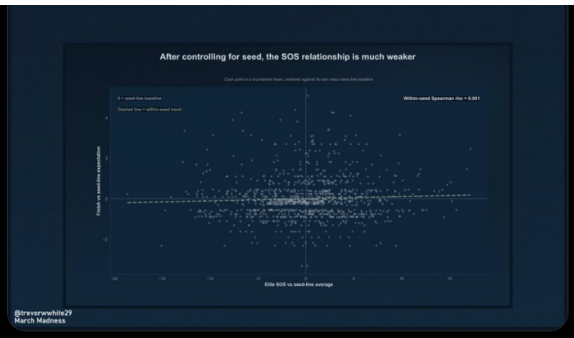
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Of course a tough strength of schedule correlates strongly with deep runs, but does it predict them?

After controlling for exact seed line, the relationship weakens significantly.

This casts some doubt as to how much "battle tested" really matters on its own.





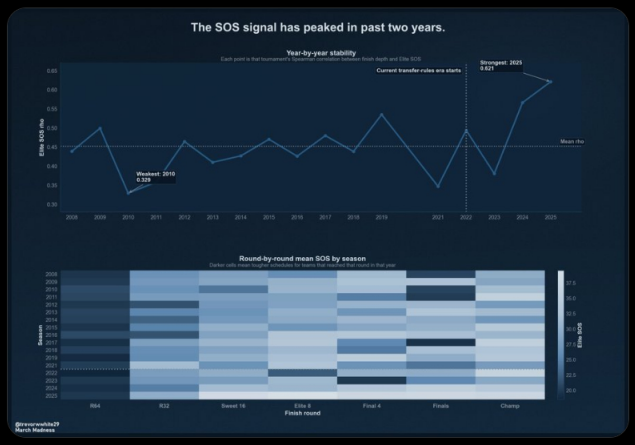
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That said, it is interesting to look at the relationship over time.

In particular, we have seen all-time highs in back to back years.

Is this a trend of significance now that teams have adjusted to life in the portal? That remains to be seen, but it is worth keeping in mind.



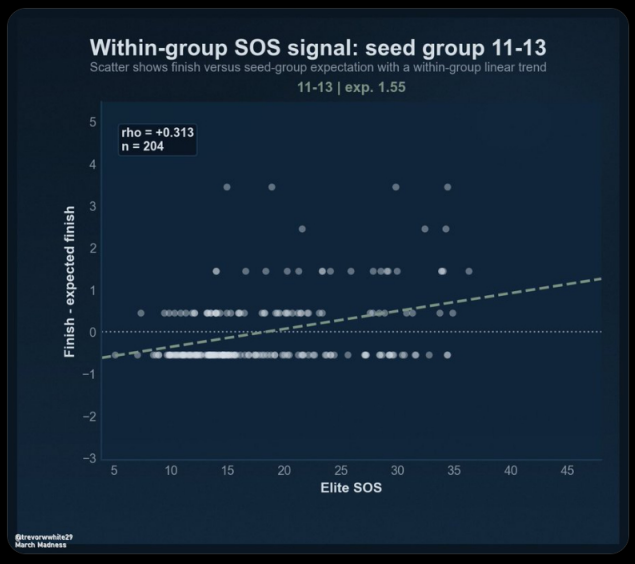
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So when does SOS actually matter?

To answer this, I separated the seeds into groups of 2-3, ignoring 14-16 seeds.

We see the strongest trend by far in the 11-13 seed band. Suggesting battle-tested low seeds are dangerous.



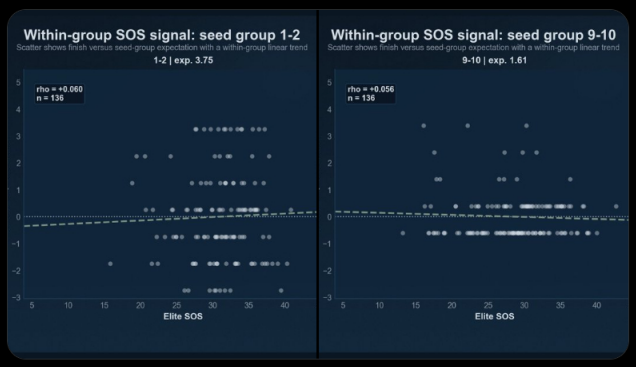
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The next strongest is the 1-2 lines, indicating that top seeds benefit from a tough SOS.

On the other side, we see a negative relationship for seeds 7-10 suggesting

On the other side, we see a negative relationship for seeds 7-10 suggesting that middling Power conference teams are vulnerable.



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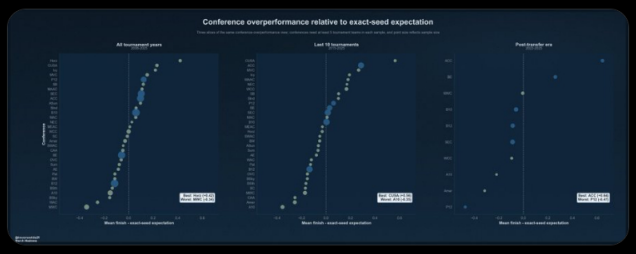
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Now, which conferences thrive and which fail to meet the (one shining) moment?

The MWC has historically struggled but stabilized in recent years.

While the ACC and BE seem to hit their stride in March.

And it looks like bball certainly didn't help the Pac12.

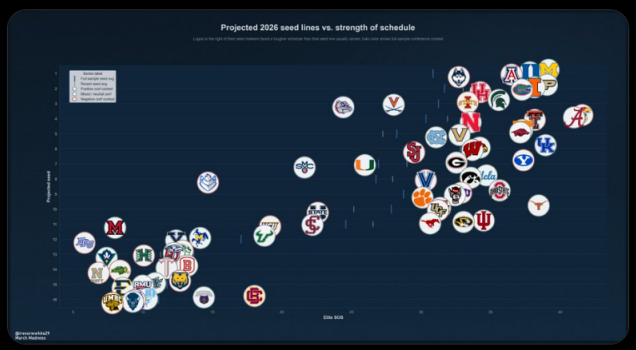


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Now for the fun part, what does this say about 2026?

Like I mentioned before, it is worth weighting SOS lightly in all cases given the trend of the L2 years.



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But more specifically,

Conferences:
CUSA: Watch out for Liberty despite the low SOS, CUSA is no stranger to madness.

ACC: They've overperformed in March consistently this past decade.

AMER: The American conference has struggled.

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High seeds:
Michigan and Duke seem the best prepared for a deep run.

Uconn is Uconn, but their SOS is 4.5% lower vs. when they won as a 1 in 2024.

Arizona, Florida are in reach.

Can Illinois and Purdue put 6 W's together? Unlikely, but they're battle tested and it may show.

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Middle seeds:
Texas may not be able to cash in their experience.

Don't be concerned about Saint Louis' schedule.

I'd like Miami OH more if they could get a 10 seed, a 6 seed would be tough for them to handle with their low SOS.

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Low seeds:
If VCU, USF, or Santa Clara make it, watch out.

On the other hand: if SMU, Missou, or Indiana are in it, don't be surprised by an early L even if they're favored.

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Thanks for reading! I'll put together more formal write-ups on these when I get the chance, any feedback is greatly appreciated, happy madness!!

Tomorrow's topic: Size.

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Relevant people

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USD Baseball Analytics • Sr. Data Scientist @Good360USA • Other sports data (is it March again yet?)

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